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proposed bill - The end of Skittles, other ‘toxic’ snacks?

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Author: By Christian Martinez Los Angeles Times | Section: News | 263 Words
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The snack and candy aisles at your local grocery store could soon carry fewer items if a bill proposed by California Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel is voted into law.

Last month, Gabriel, a Woodland Hills Democrat, introduced AB 418, which would ban the sale, manufacture and distribution of foods containing chemicals that have been linked to health concerns including decreased immune response, hyperactivity in children and increased risk of cancer.

The bill would make California the first state to ban the sale and manufacture of foods containing the chemicals, according to a release from Gabriel’s office.

The chemicals, currently banned in the European Union, are found in numerous snack staples including Skittles, Mountain Dew, Ding Dongs (with red heart sprinkles) and a host of other ubiquitous food items.

California lawmakers backing the bill pointed to a number of scientific studies that showed links between the chemicals which include red dye no. 3, titanium dioxide, potassium bromate, brominated vegetable oil and propyl paraben and health issues. In one study cited by Gabriel’s office, titanium dioxide, used in Skittles as a colorant, was found to be associated with decreased immune responses in rats.

A lawsuit filed last year in California against Mars, which manufactures Skittles, claimed that the colorful confections were “unfit for human consumption” due to titanium dioxide.

The substance is approved by the FDA, which says it can make up no more than 1% of the food by weight.

“Californians shouldn’t have to worry that the food they buy in their neighborhood grocery store might be full of dangerous additives or toxic chemicals,” Gabriel said last month in a release.

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